

BUS500 – Foundations for Business Impact

Evening & Online MBA Program – Course Syllabus

FALL 2026

Instructor	Josh Peterson (<i>please call me “Josh”</i>)		
Email	Josh.Peterson@colostate.edu (preferred method of communication)		
Class Time	5:30 – 9:10pm MDT, Thursdays		
Class Dates	August 27 – October 18 IMPORTANT: FINAL EXAM DUE SUNDAY, Oct 18, 11:59pm MT – No Exceptions		
Class Location	Rockwell West 118 (or ONLINE)		
Office Hours	Happy to meet by appointment. (Please contact IC first for a prompt response) Schedule appointment here: https://calendly.com/jopete1-colostate/30min		
Instructional Coordinators	Rod Thirion (Lead IC)	rodney.thirion@colostate.edu	NOTE: Please refer to Canvas to determine your assigned IC.
	Amy Walla	amy.walla@colostate.edu	
	Scott Kinner	scott.kinner@colostate.edu	

Course Objectives

The goal of BUS500 is to give you a sound business understanding and starting point which you can leverage and build upon in your other MBA business courses.

Upon completion of this course, students will:

- Understand a conceptual framework for business processes, systems, and structures.
- Gain proficiency in general business terminology.
- Comprehend the business model concept, including the 9 building blocks that determine how a company generates revenue and operates (Customer Segments, Value Propositions, Channels, Customer Relationships, Revenue Streams, Key Resources, Key Activities, Key Partnerships, and Cost Structure).
- Apply the business model concept to real companies.
- Understand the value chain concept, its functions (R&D, Production, Distribution, Marketing, Sales, Service, Finance, and Human Resources), and how it delivers valuable products/services to the market.
- Analyze examples of the general business framework in action, focusing on company functions, collaboration, product development, and defining company culture.
- Recognize how business functions contribute to profitability and company value and understand their measurement for effectiveness.
- Learn a framework and tools for creating a business strategy, cascading it through various organizational levels, and fostering accountability and measurable results.
- Gain a business owner perspective on the three key financial statements and the three key bottom lines, providing a clear understanding of the business's overall performance (note: this is not an accounting or finance class but will cover essential financial basics from an ownership standpoint).

Class Organization & Activities

- **Lectures:** The lectures are designed to complement and deepen your understanding of the course readings. To get the most out of each lecture, ensure you've completed the assigned readings beforehand. Your success hinges on thorough preparation and active engagement with the content.
- **Guest experts:** Our learning will be enhanced by various guest experts who will visit our class. The depth and quality of your engagement with their content will largely depend on your prior preparation from the assigned readings.
- **Canvas:** We'll use Canvas as our central hub for announcements, information sharing, assignments, quizzes, discussion prompts, and exams. Students must check Canvas regularly to stay updated with course-related information.

Course Materials:

The course will emphasize classroom discussion which will require that you are current on your reading assignments. The readings have been handpicked to be informative yet concise, and they are more engaging than traditional textbooks. This approach aims to make your reading experience both pleasurable and manageable.

<i>Readings</i>	<i>Where to acquire</i>
From Good Ideas to Great Results: How to Speak Business and Make an Impact by Josh Peterson (Aug 2025)	Canvas – Module 1
The Five Competitive Forces that Shape Strategy by Michael Porter (Jan, 2008)	Electronic Reserves CSU Library (Instructions for accessing will be provided on Canvas) <i>NOTE: Due to copyright restrictions, these readings will not be available until the first official day of class.</i>
Marketing Strategy – An Overview by Raymond Corey (Mar, 2003)	
Analysis without Paralysis: Chapter 13 – Value Chain Analysis by B. Bensoussan and C. Fleisher	
Leadership That Gets Results by Daniel Goleman	
Harvard Business Course Pack: - Stop the Innovation Wars - H&M in China	https://hbsp.harvard.edu/import/1437326 <i>NOTE: You will need to set up an account and purchase these readings.</i>
Managing by the Numbers by Kremer and Rizzuto (ISBN: 978-0-7382-0256-3)	CSU Bookstore or Amazon
Leading with Vision by Hagemann, Vetter, and Maketa (ISBN: 9781473696068)	

NOTE: Additional articles may be occasionally added throughout the course based on current events.

Grading:

Learning Activity	Max Points	%
Pre-Class Assignments (1x30)	30	3%
Assignments (6x80)	480	48%
Quizzes (6X15)	90	9%
Exams (2x160)	320	32%
Participation (8x10)	80	8%
TOTAL	1000	100%
Grading Scale	934 -1000	A
	900 - 933	A-
	867 - 899	B+
	800 - 866	B
	767 - 799	C+
	700 - 766	C
	600 - 699	D
	< 600	F

Exams - 320 points (32%)

There will be two exams administered during the course. The exams will cover content from the reading material as well as content discussed during the class.

Quizzes – 90 points (9%)

Weekly quizzes are made available immediately following the lecture and must be completed by 11:59 p.m. the Wednesday evening before the subsequent week begins. Quizzes will be timed and have 5-10 questions.

NOTE: All exams and quizzes are accessible through Canvas and must be completed within a specified timeframe once initiated. The Respondus LockDown Browser is mandatory for participation. While they are open book/note, students must complete them individually. Any form of collaboration, content sharing, or use of Artificial Intelligence is considered cheating. Those found cheating could receive a zero on the exam, fail the course, and face potential dismissal from the MBA program.

Participation – 80 points (8%)

The ability to articulate ideas, interact with others, and create shared meanings are critical components of business communication and collaboration. Because the interaction and sharing of information among students in the course can be of great benefit to all, students are encouraged to share their questions, experiences, knowledge, and perspectives with their fellow students. Students are expected to be professional and respectful of others during online discussions. Participation will be measured in the following way:

- **'LIVE' On-campus & MOSAIC Students** - Participation will be measured by tracking class engagement by keeping camera on (MOSAIC students), making comments, and asking/answering questions. The IC will monitor the comments made and evaluate them for contribution. Please avoid monopolizing any conversations and be sure to give others a chance to contribute. Students are expected to attend all class sessions; however, if an extenuating circumstance arises, communicate with the Lead IC regarding missing class, and you can watch lecture materials in Canvas.
- **Online Students** - Online students will engage with the class content using the weekly discussion submissions/comments. During weeks 1, 3, 5, and 7, students will be prompted with a discussion topic to respond to. In the alternating weeks, the students will need to respond to/comment on two other submissions from the week prior. Discussions/comments will be evaluated for legitimacy and quality.

Evaluation Criteria for Assignments/Discussions

In addition to specific requirements listed in the assignment descriptions and/or in the rubrics on Canvas, the ICs will use the following criteria to grade projects in this course.

- **Supported Quality of Work:**
 1. Each statement or explanation is supported by sound facts, logic, or data points.
 2. Analysis yields complex and nuanced syntheses of ideas, demonstrating true understanding.
- **Accurate Class Concept Use:**
 1. Class concepts are used throughout the assignment in a manner that demonstrates a full understanding of the concept.
- **Critical Thinking:**
 1. Exercises include data and reasoning that confirms or disconfirms the thesis.
 2. The analysis or explanation demonstrates an understanding of the uncertainty surrounding the facts, logic, and conclusions.
- **Mechanics and Professionalism:**
 1. Work is professionally presented and free from grammatical or typographical errors.
 2. Headings, images, figures, and tables are appropriately and effectively used.
- **WOW Factor:**
 1. 5-10% of the total grade will be determined by the WOW factor. This is evidence of work that exceeds expectations. These points are reserved for those projects that go beyond assignment requirements and demonstrate creativity, extra effort, and refined professionalism.

Instructional Coordinators (IC)

We are fortunate to have very experienced professionals as ICs for this course. Please direct all course-related inquiries to your assigned IC as your first point of contact, and they will assist with any clarifications and answers to your questions. Your assigned IC will be grading all assignments and exams, which may take up to a week. Expect email responses from your IC within 24 hours. Remember to engage with the IC's professionally and respectfully. For IT/Tech or Library support, kindly contact the respective departments.

Late Policy

You are expected to manage your schedule and meet assigned deadlines. Items turned in within 24 hours after a deadline will receive a 25% penalty. Items turned in 24-48 hours late will receive a 50% penalty. Items submitted more than 48 hours late will not be accepted. Any exceptions must be approved in advance by your Instructional Coordinator. Late submission is not allowed for the final exam. **NOTE: Pay close attention to the due date of the final exam, as it due on Sunday, October 18th at 11:59pm MT.**

Academic Integrity:

All students are expected to follow University policies with respect to academic honesty and integrity such as avoiding all forms of cheating, plagiarism, use of AI-generated content, or knowingly furnishing false information to the University. It is required that you work independently of others on all graded items (unless it is a group project). Failure to do so is a violation of academic integrity standards and will have potentially severe consequences. Consequences may include a failing grade in the course, and dismissal from the MBA program. We will be following the [Academic Integrity Policy](#) of the General Catalog and the Student Professional Conduct Code.

Artificial Intelligence (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and all others):

Each course in your MBA program is likely to have different policies around the use of artificial intelligence (AI), and it is critically important that you respect and adhere to the direction of each professor.

My goal is to encourage ***responsible collaboration*** with AI in BUS500. I believe that you are pursuing your MBA to learn the tools and gain the knowledge you need to excel in your career and that AI will become increasingly critical over time. In BUS500, you are encouraged to use AI as a tutor, study buddy, reading partner, idea collaborator, and proofreader. We will discuss how AI might be helpful in these activities during our first class. AI does have the potential to diminish learning opportunities and undermine the very reason you are investing your time and money in this education, so I will be enforcing the following guidelines and restrictions:

For graded assignments, assume that "pure AI use" (copy/paste directly from generative AI) is prohibited and will be considered plagiarism (unless otherwise indicated by me). Here at CSU, we have access to anti-plagiarism and AI detection tools (ex. Turn-It-In) that we use to ensure your work is original. **AI tools are NOT to be used for Quizzes or Exams.** I will be permitting (and encouraging) you to collaborate with AI, but you must adhere to these guidelines/restrictions:

- a) Cite any content generated by generative AI as a source, including the name of the AI tool and prompts used.
- b) Avoid using any specific data or quotes from AI tools that cannot be traced back to the original source. AI is known to generate fictitious quotes and data or pull from unreliable or unknown sources. Note that you are responsible for any AI generated content that you use and its accuracy.
- c) Provide a brief "AI Reflection" sentence (or paragraph) with your assignment in which you share how you used AI and what you learned from the experience.

NOTE: With AI evolving so quickly, I reserve the right to update this policy as I see fit. Any changes will be posted on Canvas.

Class Schedule

Below is the current schedule for the course, however I reserve the right to make changes.

Module 1: Aug 27	Overview and Introduction to Business Business Model; Business Plan; Terminology; Organization Structures and Functions Pre-readings: ✓ <i>From Good Ideas to Great Results: How to Speak Business and Make an Impact</i> by Josh Peterson [Required] ✓ <i>Dear Self: Quit Doing the Bare Minimum</i>: https://www.entrepreneur.com/article/345413 Deliverables: ✓ Copyright and Academic Integrity Acceptance Form (Due: Aug 27) ✓ Personal Questionnaire (Please try to complete it by Aug 28, Due: Sept 2) ✓ Pre-Class Quiz (Due: Sept 2) ✓ Online Discussion #1: Networking (Due: Sept 2) ✓ Week #1 Quiz: Introduction and Terminology (Due: Sept 2) ✓ Business Profile Assignment (Due: Sept 2)
Module 2: Sept 3	Business Models Framework and Innovation General Business Framework; Value Proposition; Business Model Canvas (BMC); Innovation Pre-readings: ✓ <i>Stop the Innovation Wars</i> by V. Govindarajan and C. Trimble [Recommended] Deliverables: ✓ Comment on 2 other Discussion Topic posts (Due: Sept 9) ✓ Week #2 Quiz: BMC and Innovation (Due: Sept 9) ✓ BMC assignment due (Due: Sept 9)
Module 3: Sept 10	Business Strategy, The Five Forces, and other Strategy Tools Essentials of Strategic Management; Porter's Five Forces Model; Strategic Planning; Strategy Tools Pre-readings: ✓ <i>The Five Forces that Shape Strategy</i>, by Michael Porter [Required] ✓ Video: Porter's 5 Forces EXPLAINED by B2U [Recommended] ✓ Video: StratOp Process Introduction [Recommended] Deliverables: ✓ Online Discussion #2: Strategy (Due: Sept 16) ✓ Week #3 Quiz: Strategy and Five Forces (Due: Sept 16) ✓ Five Forces Assignment due (Due: Sept 16) Guest: TBD
Module 4: Sept 17	Marketing Strategy and Company Culture Overview of Marketing Strategy; Company Culture Pre-readings: ✓ <i>Marketing Strategy - An Overview</i> by Raymond Corey [Recommended] Deliverables: ✓ Comment on 2 other Discussion Topic posts (Due: Sept 23) ✓ Midterm Exam (Due: Sept 23) Guest: TBD



Module 5: Sept 24

Supply Chain, Quality and Corporate Social Responsibility

Manufacturing and supply chain processes, Quality thinking and culture, Business practices aimed at improving the community, economy, or environment

Pre-readings:

- ✓ Video: *What is CSR?*: [VIDEO LINK](#)
- ✓ Case Study: *H&M in China* by A. Inkpen and J. Gamso [Required]

Deliverables:

- ✓ Online Discussion #3: Supply Chain (Due: Sept 30)
- ✓ Week #5 Quiz: Supply Chain, Quality, and CSR (Due: Sept 30)
- ✓ H&M in China Case Study Due (Due: Sept 30)

Guest: Arthur Valdez (Amazon, Target, Starbucks) – Supply Chain and Operations

Module 6: Oct 1

Economics, Value Chain, and Entrepreneurship

How the functions in a company's value chain contribute to the company and profitability

Pre-readings:

- ✓ *Analysis without Paralysis, Chapter 13 Value Chain Analysis* by Bensoussan [Recommended]
- ✓ Economics Crash Course Videos: [Introduction](#), [Specialization & Trade](#), and [Supply & Demand](#) (Watch all three videos if you need a refresher or haven't taken an economics course before)

Deliverables:

- ✓ Comment on 2 other Discussion Topic posts (Due: Oct 7)
- ✓ Week #6 Quiz: Value Chain and Entrepreneurship (Due: Oct 7)
- ✓ Value Chain Assignment due (Due: Oct 7)

Module 7: Oct 8

Financial Statements

Income Statements, Balance Sheet, Cash Flow, Financial Statement Analysis

Pre-readings:

- ✓ *Managing by the Numbers* by Kremer and Rizzuto (only through Chapter 10) [Required]

Deliverables:

- ✓ Online Discussion #4: Finance (Due: Oct 14)
- ✓ Week #7 Quiz: Financial Statements (Due: Oct 14)
- ✓ Personal Balance Sheet and Income Statement due (Due: Oct 14)

Guest: TBD

Module 8: Oct 15

Leadership

Effective Leadership Styles, Leading Change, Course review

Pre-readings:

- ✓ *Leadership That Gets Results* by Daniel Goleman [Recommended]
- ✓ *Leading with Vision* by Hagemann, Vetter, and Maketa (Chapters 1-6) [Required]

Deliverables:

- ✓ Comment on 2 other Discussion Topic posts (Due: SUNDAY, 11:59pm MDT, Oct 18)
- ✓ Final Exam due (Due: SUNDAY, 11:59pm MDT, Oct 18)

Guest: Jim Z (retired from HP) – Leadership, Career Development

APPENDIX

Professionalism & Academic Integrity

Students are expected to behave in a manner consistent with a graduate-level business course. If classroom or online behavior does not meet this expectation, the student's final grade may be weighted according to his/her participation and professionalism. In addition, all students are expected to follow University policies with respect to academic dishonesty such as cheating, plagiarism, or knowingly furnishing false information to the University. This instructor will adhere to the Academic Integrity Policy of the General Catalog and the Student Professional Conduct Code.

For more information about practicing academic integrity at CSU, visit
<https://resolutioncenter.colostate.edu/academic-integrity/>

Student Professional Code of Conduct

Department of Marketing

Students must uphold the academic integrity standards as explained in the university's in the [Student Conduct Code](#). Academic integrity is conceptualized as doing and taking credit for one's own work. Violations of the university's academic integrity standards include, but are not limited to:

- Cheating in the classroom. "Cheating includes using unauthorized sources of information and providing or receiving unauthorized assistance on any form of academic work."
- Plagiarism. "Plagiarism includes the copying of language, structure, ideas, or thoughts of another, and representing them as one's own without proper acknowledgment."
- Unauthorized Possession or Disposition of Academic Materials. "Unauthorized possession or disposition of academic materials includes the unauthorized selling or purchasing of examinations or other academic work; stealing another student's work; unauthorized entry to or use of material in a computer file; theft or mutilation of library materials; and using information from or possessing exams that an instructor did not authorize for release to students."
- Falsification. "Falsification encompasses any untruth, either verbal or written, in one's academic work."
- Facilitation of Cases of Academic Dishonesty. "Facilitation of any act of academic dishonesty including cheating, plagiarism, and/or falsification of documents also constitutes violation of Colorado State University's academic integrity."

Violations of Colorado State University's academic integrity policies will be handled in accordance with the procedures discussed in the [Student Conduct Code](#).

Specific Plagiarism Information

Colorado State University subscribes to TurnItIn, a web-based plagiarism detection/prevention service. Papers submitted to TurnItIn are compared to resources in the database. The results of the comparison (including hyperlinks to web pages or other papers with the same text) are then sent to the instructor. Students agree that by taking a course, all required papers, exams, class projects or other assignments submitted for credit may be submitted to turnitin.com or similar third parties to review and evaluate for originality and intellectual integrity. A description of the services, terms and conditions of use, and privacy policy of turnitin.com is available on its website: <http://www.turnitin.com>. Understand that all work submitted to turnitin.com will be added to its database of papers. Further understand that if the results of such a review support an allegation of academic dishonesty, the course work in question as well as any supporting materials may be submitted to the Student Resolution Center at CSU for investigation and further action.